The first weeks of the Robesons' stay in East Berlin were spent out of the public eye. Paul was treated by doctors at the Buch Clinic and issued a call to be "left in peace." He was taken off the sedatives and, within weeks of his arrival in East Berlin in 1963, was able to receive visitors. He spent Thanksgiving with fellow African American expatriates in East Berlin—jazz singer Audrey Pankey and cartoonist Oliver "Ollie" Harrington. Robeson remained mostly secluded but did pose for several eastern photographers while entertaining in his home or out in the streets. Eslanda also represented her husband in public, including in at least one photograph taken days after they arrived on August 28 at the Brandenburg Gate. Together, standing with border guards, Renate Mielke of the East Germany Peace Council, and a senior state official, they were pictured at the iconic gate, adjacent to but distinct from the forbidden wall. In Robeson's archives, the caption to the photograph taken near the Wall reads, "The Wall, Brandenburg Gate, E. Berlin"; similar to Davis's approach, it fails to join "Berlin" and "Wall" in a single phrase.[32] By December, Robeson's doctors agreed he was ready to go home to the States, where he would retire from public life. But before the couple left, the process had already begun for the GDR to set up an archive of the performer's cultural and historical materials. When it opened in 1965 in East Berlin, the archive became a sanctuary for Robeson's legacy.[33] In 1976 Robeson died of a stroke in Philadelphia at age seventy-seven.

Kennedy's and Robeson's trips, when juxtaposed, clarify the complicated cartography of American cultural maps of divided Berlin. Kennedy's trip, on one hand, marked one high point of Cold War West German–American state relations. His appearances promoted the language and imagery of an American identity and citizenship that was tethered to a vision for a unified, full Berlin. He accomplished this by having his speech and presence in West Berlin widely publicized and his movements shown within paces of the border wall looking out to the East without setting foot there. For Robeson, his 1963 visit to East Berlin evinced the GDR's long-standing commitment to dissident African Americans. It also marked his troubled status as an American public figure whose family felt safest treating his illness in East Berlin after his ordeal in allied London. The Robesons did not publicly visit West Berlin. Paul's liminal and convalescent condition in East Berlin emphasized the difficulties of his making public appearances in the west.[34] Together, these trips demonstrate how divided Berlin signified a crossroads